

● HARD

● CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

● ANSWER KEY

Words in Context

05

10 answers · Rationale-rich · Teach from doc

Q1**D****D. Providing resistance to**

Choice D is the best answer because as used in the text, "disputing" most nearly means providing resistance to. The narrator is in a taxi as it drives down a street lined with so many food vendors and shoppers that the narrator describes them as "the multitude of Paris," meaning an immense group of people. The street is essentially a large open-air market, and there are so many people pushing small wagons of goods and carrying shopping baskets that "every inch" of the taxi's progress is impeded. In other words, the people are providing resistance to the taxi's attempt to drive down the street.

Choice A is incorrect. Although in some contexts, "disputing" can mean arguing, the narrator doesn't portray the shoppers and vendors as arguing with the driver of the taxi or, indeed, arguing at all. Choice B is incorrect. Although in some contexts, "disputing" can mean expressing disapproval, the narrator doesn't suggest that the shoppers and vendors necessarily disapprove of the taxi's attempt to drive down the street. Instead, their combined presence along the street has the effect of impeding the taxi's progress. Choice C is incorrect because, as the narrator explains, both the multitude of people and the taxi are using a public space (a street) at the same time. The narrator doesn't go so far as to suggest that the people feel that they, and not the taxi, possess exclusive access to the street.

Q2

A

A. negating

Choice A is the best answer. "Negating" means "reversing" or "making invalid." Proving that Vermeer worked with students would reverse the view of him as a solitary artist.

Choice B is incorrect. "Prefiguring" means "being an early indicator of." There already existed views of Vermeer as a solitary painter, so a new painting would not be an early indicator of those views. Rather, a painting proving that Vermeer had a student would contradict those earlier views. Choice C is incorrect. "Entrenching" means "solidifying." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not solidify views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views. Choice D is incorrect. "Substantiating" means "supporting with proof." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not support views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views.

Q3

B

B. corroborate

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of a relationship between the results of randomized clinical tests of how effective common medical interventions are and the conclusions practitioners reach about such interventions in real-world settings. In this context, "corroborate" means confirm or support with evidence. The text indicates that one possible explanation for the relationship being discussed is that practitioners may overlook confounding variables—that is, additional factors other than the medical interventions being investigated that affect the observed outcomes. This means that practitioners may assume that an outcome is the direct result of a medical intervention when it is actually the result of a combination of factors. Clinical trials take steps to rule out factors other than the one being studied, so if those extra factors are actually having an effect on real-world outcomes, the trials are likely to produce conclusions different from those practitioners reach in their real-world observations. In other words, clinical trials may fail to corroborate practitioners' conclusions.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn't make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "circumvent," or find a way around or bypass, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; it's possible that researchers conducting the trials might avoid engaging with practitioners' conclusions, but findings from a study can't choose to get around something. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn't make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "disseminate," or spread widely, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; the researchers conducting the trials might choose to draw attention to practitioners' conclusions, but findings from a study can't spread anything. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn't make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "implement," or put into effect, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; the researchers conducting the trials might consider practitioners' conclusions, but findings from a study can't put anything into effect.

Q4

A

A. sanguine

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of political blogs. In this context, "sanguine" means optimistic. The text begins by noting the rise of political blogs with readily identifiable ideological alignments in the early 2000s. The text then indicates that some commentators saw this as a positive development, citing a reason why (their difference from traditional news). Finally, the text goes on to contrast those commentators with others who have a negative opinion of the rise of political blogs (because they increase political polarization among their readers). This context supports the idea that the second group of commentators is less positive than the first: thus, the second group of commentators is less optimistic, or sanguine.

Choice B is incorrect because it would not make sense in this context to describe those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs as less "recalcitrant," or obstinately uncooperative, than those commentators who supported political blogs. Choice C is incorrect because the text gives no indication that those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs are less "misanthropic," or less contemptuous of humankind, than those commentators who have a positive opinion of political blogs—there is no indication in the text that those commentators who like political blogs would be contemptuous of humankind at all. Choice D is incorrect because there is no evidence that those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs are less "earnest," or sincere, than those who have a positive opinion of such blogs—presumably, both groups of commentators hold their beliefs with equal conviction.

Q5

D

D. latent

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of baleen whale accessory spleens. In this context, “latent” means dormant or functionless. The text sets up a contrast between the idea that baleen whale accessory spleens appear not to have a function and the research indicating that the accessory spleen may actually have a role in supporting the whales’ diving mechanisms. This context therefore conveys the idea that the assumption that baleen whale accessory spleens are latent may be incorrect.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the role of the accessory spleen is “replicable,” or capable of being reproduced. The text indicates that the role of the accessory spleen seems to have no function, but some researchers think it does have a role; the text doesn’t address whether the role of the accessory spleen could or couldn’t be reproduced. Choice B is incorrect because suggesting that the role of the accessory spleen is “predetermined,” or decided in advance, wouldn’t make sense in context. Although the researchers may agree that the role of the accessory spleen or any other organ hasn’t been determined in advance, the text focuses on the idea that the accessory spleen was thought to have been functionless but may in fact serve an active role for baleen whales. Choice C is incorrect because it’s the opposite of what the context of the text is conveying. The second sentence of the text indicates that baleen whale accessory spleens may not be useless, not that they aren’t “operative,” or functional.

Q6

B

B. elasticity

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of black swan familial structures. In this context, “elasticity” means flexibility or adaptability. The text provides examples of flexible family arrangements among black swans: successful male-female breeding pairs are known to foster other pairs’ cygnets, and while they are less common, male-male pairs also successfully rear cygnets. This context therefore emphasizes the flexibility or elasticity of black swan familial structures, showing how this trait contributes to the success of the species.

Choice A is incorrect. Although close family units may show “cohesion,” which refers to unity or harmony within a group, the text’s focus is on the variety and adaptability of black swan family structures. The examples given—fostering other pairs’ cygnets and forming male-male as well as female-male pairs—highlight flexibility rather than cohesion, emphasizing family structures that vary from the model in which a breeding pair raises its own young. Choice C is incorrect. While “affection,” or fondness, might be present in black swan relationships, the text doesn’t focus on emotional bonds but rather on the structural flexibility of black swan familial arrangements. The examples provided demonstrate adaptable breeding and rearing practices rather than affectionate behaviors. Choice D is incorrect because “reciprocity” would suggest mutual exchange or cooperation between parties. Although the text mentions the fostering of cygnets by different successful breeding pairs, it doesn’t establish that this is based on reciprocal exchanges. The focus is instead on the flexibility of family structures and the effectiveness of these varied structures in rearing young.

Q7

A

A. stymie

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of the consequences of raising the age at which retirees begin receiving government funds. The text indicates that raising the age for these funds is usually discussed in terms of effects on fund recipients but that Andria Smythe is instead considering the effects on working family members who care for retirees. Smythe notes that raising the age for the funds would increase the length of time retirees are dependent on financial assistance from working family members. This is suggested to have an effect on wealth creation for those workers, and most logically, that effect would be disadvantageous. Thus, "stymie," which means to prevent or greatly hinder, is the most logical choice in context.

Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "compound" would most nearly mean multiply or greatly enhance. The text indicates that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds will increase the amount of time retirees are dependent on working family members for financial support. This would likely have a negative rather than a positive effect on wealth creation. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "disparage" would most nearly mean criticize or defame. Nothing in the text suggests that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds would defame wealth creation among working adults. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "outstrip" would most nearly mean to exceed, and nothing in the text indicates that the financial support provided to retirees would exceed the amount of wealth these workers can create. The text does suggest that workers providing funds to retirees works against those workers' wealth accumulation, but not that the support to retirees exceeds the workers' accumulated wealth.

Q8

A

A. surmised

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century household food purchases. In this context, “surmised” means formed an idea or assumption with little evidence. The text explains that certain economic historians “assumed” that large and small households spent different amounts on food per person, but that another economist found this supposition to be false based on evidence from available data. This context suggests that the economic historians made an incorrect assumption without enough consideration of evidence.

Choice B is incorrect. In this context, “contrived” would mean brought about or created through trickery. Nothing in the text suggests that the economic historians were deliberately trying to trick people with a claim about food purchasing behaviors in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century households; the text simply suggests that they made an assumption about those behaviors that another historian believes isn’t supported by the available data. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that it’s Logan and not the economic historians who “questioned,” or doubted, the assumption that large and small households in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries spent different amounts on food per person; the economic historians are the ones who made that assumption to begin with. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that some economic historians “regretted,” or felt sad or remorseful about, the food purchasing behaviors of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century households. The text focuses on the idea that the economic historians made an assumption about those behaviors that may not be supported by available data, not on the historians’ emotional response to what households did in the past.

Q9**C****C. Developed**

Choice C is the best answer because as used in the text, “contracted” most nearly means developed. The text explains that Mr. Brooke has a “too rambling habit of mind,” which the text likens to a disease, saying he is thought to have contracted it. To contract a disease means to acquire or develop a disease. In other words, the text indicates that Mr. Brooke is believed to have acquired, or developed, the habit of mind described in the text.

Choice A is incorrect. Although “contracted” can mean limited or restricted in some contexts, here Mr. Brooke is said to draw unpredictable conclusions, suggesting that he exhibits this “too rambling habit of mind,” not that it has been somehow limited or restricted. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text describes Mr. Brooke’s habit of mind, nothing suggests that those are his descriptions or, indeed, that he described his habit of mind at all. Choice D is incorrect because settled means calmed or mitigated, but here Mr. Brooke is said to draw unpredictable conclusions, suggesting that he exhibits this “too rambling habit of mind,” not that it has been somehow calmed or mitigated.

Q10**C****C. anomaly**

Choice C is the best answer. An “anomaly” is something that deviates from norms or expectations. In this case, the elkhorn coral is an anomaly because it can pass on somatic mutations, whereas most other animals can’t.

Choice A is incorrect. A “hypothesis” is “a theory about something,” but no theories are provided about elkhorn coral in this text, just facts. Choice B is incorrect. “Affinity” represents “an inclination or liking toward something.” As genetic mutations tend to occur without any conscious effort, you can’t really have an inclination toward passing on somatic mutations. Choice D is incorrect. “Corroboration” means “evidence to support or prove something.” Because elkhorn coral do the opposite of what most animals do, they do not provide corroboration of the theory that somatic mutations can’t be passed onto offspring. Rather, they show the opposite.

Notes

Accept equivalent forms (e.g. $0.25 \equiv 1/4$). For grid-in items, decimal and fraction answers are both valid.

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